INTERVIEW PACKET · 45 MINUTES · PRINT AND MARK UP

Scaia Group — Manager / Sr. Manager, Bay Area

> **You.** Rajesh Rishiyur Chandrasekaran
> **Interviewer.** Ulf Petersen (ulf.petersen@scaiagroup.com). 45 minutes.
> **Firm.** Scaia Group — supply chain consulting *and execution* boutique, founded 2026, HQ Munich and Atlanta, part of Barkawi Group (founded 1994, ~1,200 people). About six people today; plan is ~25+ in two years, plus "SCAIA Labs."
> **Their model, in their words.** "Builders and operators, not a classical consultancy." Design > Build > Operate > Autonomize. "Measurable impact beyond slides." "Built for performance at scale — not for slideware."
> **The role.** Manager / Sr. Manager reporting to Alexander Nedelchev, Senior Partner (ex-Deloitte, Roland Berger, Strategy&, Barkawi, Bain). Deliver end-to-end transformation (planning, manufacturing, digital/analytics), mainly for a newly won **"Magnificent 7" lighthouse client in the Bay Area** on a multi-year project. Own delivery; measurable cost / efficiency / resilience gains; grow West Coast relationships; first business-development contributions; help scale the firm; integrate other Barkawi Group solutions.
> **What they explicitly asked to learn.** "Where the candidate's individual and specialized know-how lies, and which parts of [our SCM map] the candidate can cover." Section 6 answers that directly. Have it ready as one sentence and as a table.

Read sections 2–5 out loud once. Section 4 is "tell me about yourself," newest to oldest. Section 5 is "why Scaia." Section 6 is the coverage map they asked for — including the honest gaps. Section 7 has seven stories, each tied to a line in the job description. Section 8 is how you would start on the lighthouse client, with one worked example. Sections 9–13 are hard questions, your questions, close, numbers, traps.

1. Who you are talking to

Check this at the start; don't assume it. His public LinkedIn (Ulf-Hendrik Petersen, Munich) still showed his previous role when this was written. His scaiagroup.com address suggests he has joined Scaia recently. If he introduces himself, listen for his title and how he describes his role at Scaia.

PUBLIC BACKGROUND	WHAT IT MEANS FOR THIS CONVERSATION
Tribe Lead, Supply Chain Automation — Rohlik Group (e-grocery, 2025–). Automated ordering for a €1.5B+ operation: 90%+ order automation, ops capacity need −50% with GenAI agents, unavailability −20%, shrink −50%. ML forecasting, agent workflows.	He has run an automation-rate program himself. Your Flexport story (60 → 97% automated, human kept for exceptions, measured weekly) is the same pattern. He will probe *how* you decided what stays human and how you measured it. Lead with that story.
Commercial Tech / Pricing & Assortment at Rohlik (2022–25); **Head of Pricing, Douglas** (beauty retail, Germany & Switzerland).	He knows beauty retail — the same world as Sephora. Don't over-explain retail. If it comes up naturally, one sentence: "You'll know the beauty-retail inventory problem from Douglas." Don't bring up his profile unprompted.
Oliver Wyman — Senior Associate to Principal / Associate Partner, Munich (2008–13, 2021–22).	Consulting rigor: structured answers, numbers with a method behind them, "so what" first. Answer the question first, then the support. He'll test whether you can work in front of a client.
Engineer by training (TU Berlin, industrial engineering).	He'll be comfortable with math. A two-line calculation helps you; a vague claim hurts.

What he is most likely listening for: (1) can you deliver measurable impact on a large client, hands-on; (2) where exactly your know-how sits, and are you honest about the gaps; (3) do you think in automation, not just process; (4) can you handle a six-person startup — ambiguity, business development, no support staff; (5) would he put you in front of a Magnificent 7 executive.

2. What they are scoring — and your proof

JD LINE	YOUR ONE-LINE PROOF	STORY
Measurable performance improvements (cost, efficiency, resilience)	Cost per container 66¢ → 3¢; $1.5M of safety stock out at 99% lead-time accuracy; 99% fill through Cyber Monday, ~$8M protected.	A, B, E
Planning — demand, supply, material	Forecast accuracy 70 → 85%; shortage alerts planners acted on in weekly S&OP; measured lead times on 200 lanes; available-to-sell across three channels.	B, C, D
Data analytics & technology (SAP, Blue Yonder, …)	S/4HANA inventory model and cutover; SAP MD04/MB52 daily reconciliation; Blue Yonder (JDA) WMS; Manhattan; Snowflake pipeline.	C, D
Digitalization, AI, autonomous supply chains	Automation rate 60 → 97% with a designed human-in-the-loop; LLM triage agent $25 → $0.40 per incident.	A, G
Take ownership of project delivery	343-task S/4HANA cutover, rollback set as a number, never fired; dual-DC WMS migration in 8 months; omni-DC go-live before peak.	D, backup
Client relationships & stakeholder management	Manhattan: told the client about a $2.5M discrepancy before fixing it and let them set the repair order; won a bigger project after.	E
Entrepreneurial, strategic + hands-on	Flipped an 18-month roadmap with a two-column cost table: value in 6 months, ~$5M avoided. Built an AI agent on my own time.	F, G

3. The 45-minute clock

MINUTE	LIKELY	YOUR JOB
0–4	Intros; he describes Scaia and the role.	Listen for the client's pain word — "inventory," "planning," "NPI," "manufacturing," "automation," "data." It picks your lead story.
4–7	"Tell me about yourself."	Section 4, 90 seconds, newest to oldest. Stop on the last line.
7–12	"Why Scaia? Why consulting? Why leave Sephora?"	Section 5. 60 seconds, then the one-liners if he splits it up.
12–32	Experience deep-dive: "Where is your know-how? Walk me through a project."	Section 6 coverage sentence, then two or three stories from Section 7 — 90 seconds each, then let him drill. Show one calculation per story.
32–38	"How would you approach [the client / a problem]?"	Section 8. Ask one clarifying question first. Diagnose → quick wins → design → automate. Give one number.
38–44	Your questions.	Two from Section 10.
44–45	Close.	Section 11.

45 minutes is short. Keep each story to 90 seconds unless he asks for more. A tight answer followed by "I can go into the numbers if useful" is better than four minutes.

4. "Tell me about yourself" — newest to oldest, 90 seconds

SAY THIS, THEN STOP — ABOUT 90 SECONDS

"I've spent twelve years on one problem — making sure inventory is where the demand is, and making the plan run in the real systems. Four companies, most recent first.

Sephora, today. I own how inventory is defined, placed and promised across stores, the warehouse and dotcom on S/4HANA. Five teams had five definitions of 'available'; I got it to one, reconciled nightly against the warehouse, and we stopped overselling.

Flexport, before that. Shipment tracking was being done by people typing in milestones. I helped turn it into an automated product and built the weekly review that ran it: the share of containers tracked with no human touch went from about sixty to ninety-seven percent, and cost per container from sixty-six cents to three, while we grew from seven customers to sixty-eight.

Elementum. Supply-chain planning software. I replaced carrier brochure lead times with measured ones on two hundred lanes, which released about a million and a half dollars of safety stock at 99% accuracy. I also built shortage alerts on clients' SAP data that planners trusted enough to act on in their weekly planning meeting.

Manhattan Associates, where I started. Allocation and order promising for a retail client with three mega-DCs and a hundred stores — 99% fill through Cyber Monday, about eight million dollars of orders protected.

So: planning, the systems it runs on, and the automation on top — designed, built and run, not just recommended. That's why Scaia's model caught my attention."

30-SECOND VERSION, IF HE'S MOVING FAST

"Most recent first. Sephora: one definition of inventory across every channel on S/4HANA. Flexport: tracking automation from sixty to ninety-seven percent, sixty-six cents a container down to three. Elementum: measured lead times on two hundred lanes, a million and a half of stock released. Manhattan: 99% fill through Cyber Monday for a retail client. Planning, systems, automation — designed, built and run."

Why this ending works for Scaia: "designed, built and run, not just recommended" is their own pitch ("builders and operators, not a classical consultancy"). Don't name their framework yet — save Design > Build > Operate > Autonomize for "why Scaia."

5. Why Scaia. Why consulting. Why now.

He will want to know three things: why consulting after years in industry; why a six-person firm instead of a big one; and why now. Answer with what's in their own material, matched to something you have done.

WHAT SCAIA SAYS	WHERE YOU'VE ALREADY DONE IT	WHY IT LANDS
Design > Build > Operate > Autonomize. "Builders and operators."	Flexport tracking: designed what to automate, built it in waves, ran it in a weekly review, then took the human out of 97% of it. That's all four steps in one project.	You don't have to learn their model. You've done it.
Planning, postponement & execution; technology & AI enablement (ERP, planning, WMS, OMS, analytics).	S/4HANA inventory model, SAP data reconciliation, Blue Yonder and Manhattan execution systems, forecast and shortage alerts, an AI agent.	Your experience covers the planning-to-execution-to-data part of their map.

WHAT SCAIA SAYS	WHERE YOU'VE ALREADY DONE IT	WHY IT LANDS
Lighthouse client in the Bay Area, multi-year; West Coast growth.	Your career is in the Bay Area supply-chain ecosystem — Sephora, Flexport, Elementum. *[Confirm you are Bay Area–based before saying "local."]*	You can be on-site, and you know how tech companies run decisions.
Build-up from ~6 to ~25+; SCAIA Labs; integrate Barkawi solutions.	You've built things from a blank sheet: the Flexport review, the Elementum alerts, an agent on your own time.	An early hire helps decide what the firm becomes. That's the appeal, not a risk you're tolerating.

WHY SCAIA — 60 SECONDS, SPOKEN

"Three reasons.

First, the model. You say you're builders and operators, not a classical consultancy — design, build, operate, then automate. That's the arc of the work I'm proudest of. At Flexport we designed what to automate in shipment tracking, built it in waves, ran it in a weekly review, and got to ninety-seven percent with no human touch. I want to do that for clients, not one company at a time.

Second, the fit. The lighthouse work is planning, data and digital in a Bay Area tech company. That's where my experience is: planning on SAP, the execution systems underneath, and the automation on top.

Third, the timing. Scaia is six people heading to twenty-five. Joining now means I help build the practice, the client relationships and the way the firm works — not just staff a project. That's a rare chance, and it's why I'm talking to you and not to a big firm."

If he splits it up:

- *"Why consulting, after years in industry?"* — "I've always been on the delivery side of someone else's problem — Manhattan's retail client, Elementum's manufacturing clients. At Sephora and Flexport I learned to own the result. Scaia's model asks for both: advise the client and own the result."
- *"Why leave Sephora?"* — "What I came to do is live: the inventory model on S/4HANA is the standard, and the migration is done. If I stay, I run the same play again. Here I run it across clients, and help build the firm that does it."
- *"Why a boutique, not Deloitte or Accenture?"* — "At a big firm I'd be one of thousands running a method someone else wrote. At Scaia the method is still being written, and the client work is hands-on. I'd rather help write it."
- *"Are you comfortable with the risk of a startup?"* — "Yes. It's backed by Barkawi, it already has a multi-year anchor client, and the work is what I do. The real risk for me would be a role where I only make slides."

Don't say: "I want to learn consulting," "I'm looking for more strategic work" (sounds like you want to stop doing the hands-on part), or anything that guesses which Magnificent 7 company the client is.

6. Where your know-how sits on their map

The JD asks this directly, and it included a graphic of the SCM environment (agents, tools, systems, data sources) that didn't come through in your copy. Ask him to share it or walk you through it — that alone is a good question. Then give the sentence and, if he wants detail, the table.

> **THE ONE-SENTENCE ANSWER**
>
> "My deepest know-how is in planning — demand, supply and material — and the data and systems it runs on: SAP, warehouse and order systems, and the reconciliation that makes the numbers trustworthy. On top of that, automation: deciding what a machine should do, what stays with a person, and measuring it every week. I'm working-level on manufacturing and postponement — I've planned material into factories, not run the floor — and I haven't implemented Kinaxis or o9, though I know what they're solving."

AREA ON THEIR MAP	LEVEL	EVIDENCE — SAY THE NUMBER
Demand planning	**Deep**	Forecast accuracy 70 → 85% at SKU-location-week (Elementum); three-channel demand into one available-to-sell (Sephora).
Supply & material planning; inventory policy	**Deep**	Lead times measured on 200 lanes, $1.5M safety stock out at 99%; shortage alerts on coverage math; ~$2M safety stock under a two-signal rule.
Order promising & allocation (OMS); fulfillment execution	**Deep**	3 mega-DCs / 100 stores, 99% fill at peak (Manhattan); available-to-sell across stores, DC and dotcom (Sephora).
Warehouse / DC capacity & throughput	**Deep**	Two DCs into one robotic omni DC, +15% processing efficiency; dual-DC Blue Yonder (JDA) WMS migration in 8 months.
Logistics / transportation visibility	**Deep**	Flexport tracking product, 7 → 68 customers, automation 60 → 97%.
Supply chain data & analytics	**Deep**	SAP MD04/MB52 daily reconciliation held at zero drift; Zendesk + platform data into Snowflake; metric definitions and weekly reviews.
AI, agents, automation design	**Working → deep**	Automation rate and human-in-the-loop design at Flexport; LLM triage agent built myself, $25 → $0.40 per incident, with an evaluation set first.
S&OP / IBP process	**Working**	Shortage alerts entered weekly S&OP; haven't owned an executive S&OP cycle end to end.
Manufacturing — process, postponement	**Working / gap**	Planned production orders, POs and ASNs from client SAP at Elementum; pooled inventory across channels at Sephora is postponement of the channel decision. Not run a plant or a configure-to-order line. See the bridge below.
Network design (LlamaSoft / Coupa)	**Working**	DC consolidation decision and cost-to-serve modeling; not built a LlamaSoft model.
Tools — SAP (S/4HANA, ECC)	**Deep**	Inventory model, stock states, returns plant, RTV transfers, cutover; MD04/MB52.
Tools — Blue Yonder, Manhattan	**Deep (execution side)**	Blue Yonder/JDA WMS migration and omni DC; Manhattan allocation and promising. Not Blue Yonder's planning suite.
Tools — Kinaxis, o9	**Not hands-on**	Know the logic (concurrent planning, scenario-based supply/demand matching) because I've built the same logic elsewhere. Would get hands-on fast. *[If you've had any exposure, say it specifically.]*

AREA ON THEIR MAP	LEVEL	EVIDENCE — SAY THE NUMBER
Procurement / sourcing; after-sales service parts	**Light**	Inbound lanes and vendor ASN gates (1,000 routes, ≥ 95% valid ASNs) — not strategic sourcing.

The gap answers — say them plainly

"Have you used Kinaxis or o9?" — "Not hands-on. What those tools do — match supply to demand by week, run scenarios, and flag shortages — I've built and run on SAP data at Elementum, and run on S/4HANA at Sephora. The planning logic is the same; the tool is configuration. I'd want to be hands-on within the first month of the project." *Don't claim more.*

"What do you know about manufacturing and postponement?" — "I haven't run a factory. I've planned the material going into factories — production orders, purchase orders and supplier shipments from SAP — and I've designed postponement on the inventory side. At Sephora, the warehouse holds one pool of stock and doesn't commit it to stores or dotcom until there's an order. That's postponing the channel decision, and it's the same math as postponing the configuration of a product." Then, if he wants it, the math below.

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POSTPONEMENT, THE SIMPLE VERSION  (illustrative numbers — how you'd reason, not a past result)
   One base product, finished in 3 configurations. Each sells ~1,000/week, weekly swing σ = 300.
   Lead time 6 weeks. Target 95% service → z = 1.65.

   Finish early (hold 3 finished stocks):  safety stock each = 1.65 × 300 × √6 = 1,212
                                           total             = 3 × 1,212        = 3,637 units
   Postpone (hold 1 base stock, configure on order):
                                           swing of the total = √3 × 300         = 520
                                           safety stock       = 1.65 × 520 × √6  = 2,100 units
   Saving = 3,637 − 2,100 = 1,537 units  →  about 42% less safety stock, same service

   Catch: works only if the configurations' demand isn't moving together (if all three spike
   at once, saving shrinks), and only if you can configure fast enough for the customer lead time.
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7. The stories — each tied to a line in the job description

Seven stories. Lead with A. Then pick by the pain word you heard in minute 0–4: *inventory / planning* → B or C; *SAP / systems / data* → D or C; *client / stakeholder* → E; *strategy / business case* → F; *AI / agents* → G. Each one: problem, goal, metric, result; a 90-second spoken version; one simple calculation; the tie to Scaia; and the probes he'll likely ask.

A. Flexport Shipment Visibility — from people typing milestones to 97% automated (lead story)

Problem	Clients wanted to see all their containers in one app, including ones Flexport didn't ship. When the system couldn't start tracking a container automatically, it opened a support ticket and an operator looked it up on the carrier's website and typed the milestones in. Seven customers, ~2,000 containers a week, ~60% automated, 66¢ cost per container, ~60% data accuracy, no weekly review.
Goal	Leadership's goal #1: lower cost-to-serve by replacing manual tracking with automation — while the customer base grew.
Metric	Automation rate (containers tracked with no human touch ÷ containers submitted); cost per container; data accuracy; customers.
Result	Automation ~60 → 97%. Cost per container 66¢ → 3¢ (−95%) while volume grew 5×. Customers 7 → 68. Accuracy 60 → 90%. Weekly review built from scratch, then its data automated — 30 analyst hours a week down to 6 (~$104K/yr).

SAY THIS — ABOUT 90 SECONDS

"At Flexport, clients wanted to track all their containers in one place, including ones we didn't ship. When the system couldn't pick up a container automatically, it opened a ticket and someone looked it up on the carrier's website and typed it in. About sixty percent was automated, and it cost sixty-six cents a container. Leadership's top goal was to automate it — and they asked for a weekly review that nobody owned.

I took the review. Three decisions mattered. First, I made one number the headline: the share of containers tracked with no human touch. Every ticket was a failed automation, so cost and quality became the same line. Second, I kept the human in the loop on purpose — a ticket with a reason code and a 24-hour target — so every manual case told engineering exactly what to automate next. We ranked that list by tickets times cost, carrier by carrier. Third, new customers came on in waves, and a wave only went live when quality held at the current load. I held one wave when accuracy was at 76 against an 80 target.

Result: automation from sixty to ninety-seven percent, cost per container from sixty-six cents to three while volume grew five times, and customers from seven to sixty-eight."

The simple math — before and after

	BEFORE	AFTER
Containers per week	2,000	10,000
Automation rate	60%	97%
Manual tickets per week (containers not automated)	800	300
Cost per ticket (operator time) *[illustrative]*	$1.50	$0.80
Manual cost per week	$1,200	$240
Platform / data cost per week *[illustrative]*	$120	$150

	BEFORE	AFTER
Cost per container = (manual + platform) ÷ containers	**$0.66**	**~$0.04** → **$0.03** with bulk data pricing

The point to say out loud: volume grew five times but manual tickets went *down* from 800 to 300. Volume alone would only have spread the fixed cost; automation is what took it to three cents.

> **Tie to Scaia.** All four phases in one project — design (what to automate, the human-in-the-loop rules), build (waves), operate (the weekly review), autonomize (97%). Same pattern as Ulf's order-automation work. JD lines: "measurable performance improvements," "digital/analytics," "increasingly autonomous supply chains."

> **"How did you decide what stays human?"** — Where the data source was missing or unreliable, and where a wrong answer cost more than a slow one. Every manual case got a reason code, so the human loop doubled as the backlog. A carrier left the human loop when it stayed above 95% automated for four weeks; if it dropped below 90%, it came back in.
>
> **"How did you prioritize what to automate?"** — Value per engineering week: tickets per week × cost per ticket, plus customer interactions removed, divided by the build effort. A terminal with fewer tickets but a half-week build beat a big carrier with a three-week build.
>
> **"Why hold a wave at 76 vs 80?"** — Because adding customers to a system that's already missing on quality multiplies tickets. 70% of the misses came from one data source; we fixed it, added a kill switch, re-tested for a week, and boarded.
>
> **"What was yours vs the team's?"** — The metric definitions, the review, the human-in-the-loop rules, the wave gate and the prioritization. Engineering built the service.

B. Elementum — 200 lanes: planned on measured lead times, $1.5M of safety stock released

Problem	Inventory plans used the carrier's brochure transit time — one optimistic number per lane, never checked. Planners padded safety stock by feel.
Goal	Lead times that hold 99% of the time, with *less* safety stock, not more.
Metric	Lead-time accuracy (arrivals within planned lead time); safety stock units and dollars.
Result	99% lead-time accuracy. 580K units, ~$1.5M of safety stock released, auditable lane by lane. A drift flag per lane kept it true.

> **SAY THIS — ABOUT 90 SECONDS**
>
> "A planner asked me for a lead-time report. Underneath, the plan ran on brochure transit times — one number per lane that nobody had checked — and planners padded safety stock to compensate. I pulled about a year of real shipments on two hundred lanes and set each lane's planned lead time to what ninety-nine out of a hundred shipments actually beat. On most lanes that was more honest than brochure-plus-padding, so the padding could go. On about a quarter of lanes reality was worse than assumed, and those got more stock, on purpose. The rule I agreed with finance: only release stock where the measured variability was lower than what the system assumed. Net result: about five hundred eighty thousand units and a million and a half dollars of safety stock released, with lead times holding ninety-nine percent of the time. And a drift flag per lane so the plan reopens itself when a lane gets worse."

The simple math — one lane, before and after

ONE LANE, SELLS 500 UNITS/DAY	BEFORE	AFTER
Planned lead time	18 days (brochure)	34 days — 99 of 100 real shipments arrived within it (average was 21)

ONE LANE, SELLS 500 UNITS/DAY	BEFORE	AFTER
How often the plan was right	Padded to ~25 days by feel; still late 7 in 100	Late 1 in 100
Safety stock	System formula ~9,400 + a "just in case" week ~3,500 = **~12,900 units**	Gap between average and planned trip: 13 days × 500 = 6,500; + demand swings ~1,600 = **~8,100 units**
This lane	**4,800 units out (~$12K)** and fewer stock-outs (1 in 100 vs 7 in 100).	
All 200 lanes	~150 lanes released ~675K units; ~50 lanes added ~95K → net **580K units ≈ $1.5M**.	

Tie to Scaia. "Service-level differentiation and inventory policy design" and "supply planning" from their service list; "resilience" and "cost" from the JD — less inventory and better service at the same time. This is a classic first-90-days quick win on any client.

"How much history?" — About a year per lane (~400 shipments, ~8 a week) so seasons and congestion were in it. Lanes with too little history stayed on the old number and were flagged as unmeasured.

"Why not use the average?" — About half of shipments are slower than average, so you'd be late roughly half the time. The worst-ever shipment is a one-off; the 99th percentile covers almost everything without carrying stock for freak events.

"How did finance trust the $1.5M?" — Lane by lane, written down before any stock moved, with the rule and who signed it.

C. Elementum — shortage alerts planners actually used: fix the data first

Problem	Planners learned about shortages when a production line stopped. Forecast accuracy ~70%. In SAP, the stock view (MB52) and the requirements view (MD04) disagreed by 8–12% on any given day, so nobody trusted an alert.
Goal	Alerts planners act on in the weekly S&OP; forecast accuracy 70 → 85%; then safety stock down.
Metric	Forecast accuracy; daily data mismatch (MD04 vs MB52); alert false-alarm rate; safety stock $.
Result	Live in three months. Mismatch 8–12% → 0, held daily. Forecast accuracy 70 → 85%. ~$2M of safety stock released. Alerts adopted into weekly S&OP without a mandate.

SAY THIS — ABOUT 90 SECONDS

"Planners at our clients found out about shortages when a line stopped. The obvious fix was an alert. The problem was the SAP data underneath: the stock view and the requirements view disagreed by eight to twelve percent every day, so any alert would be wrong often enough to be ignored. So I did the data first. I brought inventory, production orders, purchase orders, supplier shipments and forecasts into one view, and published a daily reconciliation between the two SAP views with one rule: no alert fires on a day the data doesn't match. It took three weeks to get to zero. Then the alert was simple — weeks of supply against lead time — with a one-line reason: 'PO 4471 slipped nine days.' Every alert a planner dismissed got classified and fixed weekly. Forecast accuracy went from seventy to eighty-five percent, mostly from cleaning the inputs, not a new model. About two million dollars of safety stock came out, and the alerts went into the weekly planning meeting because planners trusted them."

The simple math — one alert

STEP	EXAMPLE
Weeks of supply = (on hand + orders arriving within lead time) ÷ weekly demand	(1,200 + 800) ÷ 500 = **4.0 weeks**
What you need = lead time + safety weeks	3 + 1.5 = **4.5 weeks**
Fire the alert if supply < need *and* the data matched today	4.0 < 4.5 and data matched → **alert**
Reason line — the input that moved most	"PO 4471 slipped 9 days → 4.0 weeks of supply in week 7"
Data mismatch = Σ |MD04 stock − MB52 stock| ÷ Σ MB52 stock, daily, by plant	8–12% → 0 over three weeks

Tie to Scaia. "Planning (material)," "data analytics," "SAP." And the consulting lesson: adoption comes from trust in the data, not from the tool. This is how you'd sequence any planning-tool rollout at the lighthouse client.

"Why not ship the alert faster?" — An alert on data planners don't trust teaches them to ignore alerts. Three weeks of reconciliation bought years of trust.

"Where did the 15 points of accuracy come from?" — Stale purchase orders, duplicated demand, wrong lead times — inputs the reconciliation exposed. Not a new forecasting model.

D. Sephora S/4HANA — one definition of "available," reconciled nightly, cut over with a numeric rollback

Problem	S/4HANA was becoming the inventory system of record for stores, the DC and dotcom. "Available" meant something different to each team. Returns, quality-hold and lost-and-found stock were being promised to customers.
Goal	One definition per stock state, one owner, one rule on who can promise it; zero customer incidents at cutover; legacy system retired.
Metric	Units promised from non-sellable stock → 0; nightly mismatch between SAP and the warehouse system within tolerance; go-live incidents.
Result	Non-sellable promises → zero in production. Nightly mismatch within tolerance, every exception owned. 343-task cutover; rollback never fired; zero customer incidents; legacy system retired.

SAY THIS — ABOUT 90 SECONDS

"At Sephora, S/4HANA was becoming the system of record for inventory across stores, the warehouse and dotcom. The software wasn't the problem — the definitions were. 'Available' meant one thing to stores, another to the warehouse, another to dotcom and another to finance, so returns and damaged stock were being promised to customers. I wrote one definition for every stock state, with an owner and a rule on whether it can be promised, and got the business to sign it before anything was configured. Returns got their own location in SAP, so nothing was sellable until it was inspected. Every night we rebuilt available-to-sell from the warehouse and reconciled it to SAP, with every difference assigned to an owner by six a.m. The cutover was a 343-task runbook with the rollback written as numbers in advance. It never fired. Zero customer incidents, and we retired the legacy system. One rule I wrote was too strict — no promising stock on a truck — and the data showed it was hurting dotcom, so we fixed it through the same signed process."

The simple math — available-to-sell for one SKU at the DC

LINE	UNITS
Warehouse supply (what the WMS says is physically there)	1,000
− pack reserve (already being packed)	−40
− dotcom pick reserve	−60
− dotcom pack reserve	−30
− shipped, not yet billed	−20
+ mechanical reserve added back	+15
+ lost-and-found added back	+5
= Available to sell	**870**
SAP supply for the same SKU	880
Mismatch = 10 units (1.1%) → must be explained and owned by 6 a.m., or it's a red	**10**

Illustrative numbers. Rollback triggers, set before cutover: system sync below 99% for 4 hours, or response time over 2× budget for 1 hour.

> **Tie to Scaia.** "SAP," "alignment of planning, execution and decision systems (ERP, WMS, OMS)," "take ownership of project delivery," "transition from design into live operations." This is the Build and Operate proof.

> **"How did you get five teams to agree?"** — For each stock state I wrote down which customer gets hurt if it's promised. That turned an argument about definitions into a decision about customers.
>
> **"What would you do differently?"** — Use lane data for the in-transit rule from day one instead of forbidding it.

E. Manhattan Associates — client trust and peak execution

Use the first half for "client relationships / stakeholders," the second for "resilience / pressure." *[Confirm your exact role title at Manhattan — client delivery for a retail customer.]*

Problem	(1) A reconciliation found ~200 of the client's orders misstated between the order system and the warehouse system — about $2.5M. My manager wanted to fix it quietly. (2) Cyber Monday, 4 a.m.: backorders climbing across 3 DCs and 100 stores, cause unknown.
Result	(1) Told the client the same day with the full list; they set the repair priority; the defect class never came back; we later won a larger project. (2) Fill rate held at 99%; ~$8M of orders shipped on time; stock-outs −20% over the engagement.

SAY THIS — ABOUT 90 SECONDS

"Two moments from my first job, both about a client. First: we found about two hundred of the client's orders misstated between their order system and their warehouse — around two and a half million dollars. My manager's instinct was to fix it quietly. I argued to tell them first, took the full list to the client that day, and asked them to set the repair order, because they knew which orders mattered — stores first, then dotcom. We fixed the cause, not just the two hundred orders. The meeting was uncomfortable; the account grew. Second: Cyber Monday, four a.m., backorders climbing. Instead of clearing the oldest orders first, I ranked them by dollars at risk and hours to cutoff and moved them to DCs that still had capacity, logging every decision. The cause turned out to be a scheduler that died at the daylight-saving change. We held ninety-nine percent fill and shipped about eight million dollars of orders on time."

```
Priority = order value × urgency,  urgency = 1 ÷ hours to cutoff (minimum 0.5 h)
   $400 order, 2 h left  → 400 × 0.5  = 200
   $900 order, 9 h left  → 900 × 0.11 = 100     → the $400 order ships first
```

Tie to Scaia. "Client-focused," "build and expand client relationships," "resilience." The lesson he'll want from a future manager on a Magnificent 7 account: bad news goes to the client early, with the full list and a plan.

F. Flexport — flipping an 18-month roadmap with a two-column cost table

Problem	An inherited 18-month plan, already shown to leadership. Fixed engineering capacity. The only real choice was the order of work.
Result	Engineering effort to first value −66%; value in 6 months instead of 18; cost-to-serve cut ~50% instead of ~25%; ~$5M cost avoided.

SAY THIS — ABOUT 60 SECONDS

"I inherited an eighteen-month plan leadership had already approved. Engineering was fixed; the only choice was which half to build first. I costed both options in the one number the business was measured on — cost to serve — with identical rows and every assumption written down. One order gave value in six months and halved cost to serve; the other took eighteen months for a quarter. I took the table to my manager privately and asked him to break it. Engineering tested it for two days; it held; leadership approved the new order. Then I protected a date for the work we'd pushed back. About five million dollars avoided and value a year earlier."

	ORIGINAL ORDER	FLIPPED ORDER
Months to first value	18	6
Engineering effort to first value	100%	34% (−66%)
Cost-to-serve reduction	~25%	~50%
Cost avoided	—	~$5M

Tie to Scaia. This is a consulting deliverable — a business case that changed a decision, built in the client's own currency and tested by the people who'd have to deliver it. "Strategic thinking," "stakeholder management," "structured."

G. AI agent — built it myself, $25 → $0.40 per incident

Say in the first sentence that this was your own build, not a company program.

SAY THIS — ABOUT 45 SECONDS

"On my own time I built an AI agent to triage operational incidents, because analysts were spending about twenty-five dollars of time on each one and I wanted to learn the stack. Before writing the agent, I wrote the test: about a hundred real incidents with the right answer. No change shipped unless that test still passed, and every answer had to cite its source. Cost went from twenty-five dollars an incident to forty cents, with accuracy held. Same discipline as a supply chain rollout: decide how you'll measure before you build."

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Analyst:  20 min × [$75/h] = $25 per incident
Agent:    (model tokens + compute + retrieval) ÷ incidents ≈ $0.40   → −98%
Gate:     no change ships unless the 100+ case evaluation set still passes at baseline
```

Tie to Scaia. "AI agents to enable autonomous supply networks," SCAIA Labs. With Ulf: the point isn't that you built an agent — it's that you built the evaluation first, which is what makes agents safe to put in front of a client.

Backup — delivery stories, only if he asks about running a large program

STORY	ONE-LINE VERSION
Sephora omni DC (UDC)	Two warehouses into one robotic omni DC on Blue Yonder before peak: 15+ workstreams, 60+ stakeholders. I set a 98% pick-accuracy gate before the robots arrived; at 94% I throttled them to 30% the same day. +15% processing efficiency, zero customer incidents through peak. *Use for "capacity, throughput" and "ownership of delivery."*
Sephora dual-DC WMS migration	Two DCs from a legacy system to Blue Yonder (JDA) WMS in 8 months. Inventory-variance tolerance of 0.5% set before the first mock cutover; mocks went 7% → 1.8% → 0.3%; landed ~3% under a $1.8M budget.

8. "How would you approach the lighthouse client?"

You don't know who the client is or what the scope is — don't guess. Ask one question first: *"Is the first problem planning — inventory and service — or manufacturing and supply? And what does the client measure us on?"* Then give the shape below in about two minutes.

THE FIRST 90 DAYS — SPOKEN, ABOUT 2 MINUTES

"I'd run it in the same four steps Scaia uses.

Weeks one to three — understand and measure. Agree with the client on the three or four numbers we'll be judged on: service level, inventory, cost, and probably plan accuracy. Pull the real data — not the system's assumptions — and check it matches between systems. On every project I've done, the first surprise is in the data: lead times that were never measured, stock views that don't agree.

Weeks three to six — quick wins. Use the measured data to fix the parameters: lead times, safety stock policy by segment, obvious excess. That usually releases inventory and improves service at the same time, and it pays for the rest of the program.

Weeks six to twelve — design and build the process. A weekly review with the client's planners on those numbers — every red explained before the meeting, an owner and a date on every action — and the planning process redesigned around it.

Then automate. Once a decision is made the same way every week, and the data is trusted, measure how often it's made without a person. That's the automation rate, and it becomes the headline number."

Worked example — if he gives you a case: "cut inventory 20% without hurting service"

```
CLARIFY   What inventory — finished goods, components, or both? Which service measure, what level?
          What's driving it — forecast error, long lead times, lot sizes, or excess/obsolete?

SPLIT THE INVENTORY INTO ITS PARTS  (illustrative client: $100M of inventory)
   cycle stock (lot sizes, order frequency)        $35M
   safety stock (forecast error + lead-time swing) $40M
   excess & obsolete                               $15M
   in transit / pipeline                           $10M

WHERE THE 20% ($20M) COULD COME FROM
   excess & obsolete: sell / scrap / return a third         ≈ $5M   (one-time, fast)
   safety stock: measured lead times and segmented service
     (99% on the vital few, 95% on the long tail) — the
     Elementum method released a meaningful share of SS       ≈ $8–10M
   postponement on configurable products: ~40% less SS
     on the configured share (see Section 6)                  ≈ $3–4M
   lot sizes / order frequency on top-volume items            ≈ $2–3M
                                                    total  ≈ $18–22M → about 20%

PROTECT SERVICE   Release only where the measured number is better than the assumed one.
                  Track service weekly by segment; any segment below target gets stock back.
```

Say clearly that the split and percentages are illustrative, and that week one is replacing them with the client's real numbers.

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9. The hard questions

"You've never worked at a consulting firm." — "That's right. I've worked on the delivery side of client problems — Manhattan's retail client, Elementum's manufacturing clients — and I've owned the result inside the company at Sephora and Flexport. What I'll need to build is the consulting craft: proposals, staffing, the partner relationship. What I bring is that I've been the person who has to make the recommendation actually run."

"Manager or Senior Manager — where do you see yourself?" — "Senior Manager. I've owned programs end to end with 60+ stakeholders and executive steering, and led cross-functional teams without formal reporting lines. I'm open on title if the scope is right; I'd rather be judged on the first six months." *Don't name a salary number first. If pushed: "I'd like to understand the full package and level first."*

"How would you contribute to business development?" — "Three ways. Deliver the lighthouse so well it becomes the reference case. Bring the West Coast network I have from Sephora, Flexport and Elementum *[be ready to say what kind of companies, not names]*. And turn what we learn into repeatable offers — for example, a four-week inventory diagnostic with a guaranteed set of measured numbers at the end."

"Tell me about leading a team." — Matrix leadership: the Sephora S/4HANA program (60+ stakeholders, weekly CIO/COO pack) and coaching a QA lead to own the release gate during an agile conversion (6-week → 4-week releases, defects −50%). Say "matrix" — don't invent direct reports.

"Tell me about a failure." — The in-transit rule at Sephora: too strict, it hurt dotcom; the data showed it; fixed through the same signed process. Or the data-security review you didn't plan for at Flexport — two weeks late, owned the same day, on the kickoff checklist ever since.

"How do you handle a client who pushes back on your recommendation?" — The roadmap story (F): put it in their currency, let them try to break it privately, and commit fully once it's decided.

"Where does AI actually help in planning — and where not?" — "It helps where a decision is made the same way often, with trusted data: ordering, exception triage, data matching. It doesn't help when the data underneath

is wrong — it just fails faster. So I always measure the automation rate and keep a designed human path, with a reason code, for the cases the machine shouldn't take."

"Are you OK with travel and a startup pace?" — "Yes. *[Confirm your actual travel limits before the call.]*"

10. Your questions — pick two

1. "What does the lighthouse client need to see from Scaia in the first ninety days for the project to be judged a success?"
2. "At Scaia, how do you decide a process is ready to be automated — what has to be true about the data and the decision first?" *(He's done this at scale; it invites him to talk about his own work.)*
3. "The job description mentions a map of the SCM environment with agents, tools and data sources. Which parts matter most for the first client?"
4. "Which Barkawi Group capabilities do you expect to bring into this project, and how does that work in practice?"
5. "What would make the difference between a Manager and a Senior Manager in this role a year from now?"

11. Close — fifteen seconds

> **SAY THIS AT THE END**
>
> "Thank you. What I'd bring is the part between the plan and the result: measuring the real numbers, making them trustworthy, and running the change until it's automated. That's what Scaia says it does, and it's what I've done for twelve years. I'd like to do it with you on the lighthouse."

12. Numbers to know cold

NUMBER	WHAT IT IS
~60% → 97%; 66¢ → 3¢; 7 → 68 customers; 5× volume; 60% → 90% accuracy	Flexport tracking automation (A)
800 → 300 manual tickets a week	Why cost fell while volume grew (A)
30 → 6 analyst hours/week; ~$104K/yr	Automating the weekly review's data (A)
200 lanes; 18 → 34 days planned; 99% accuracy; 580K units; ~$1.5M	Measured lead times (B)
70% → 85% forecast accuracy; 8–12% → 0 data mismatch; ~$2M	Shortage alerts (C)
5 definitions → 1; 343-task cutover; rollback never fired; 0 incidents	S/4HANA (D)
~$2.5M discrepancy disclosed; 99% fill; ~$8M protected; −20% stock-outs	Manhattan (E)
6 vs 18 months; −66% effort; ~50% vs ~25%; ~$5M	Roadmap flip (F)
$25 → $0.40 per incident	AI agent (G)
~42% less safety stock	Postponement example, 3 configurations (illustrative, Section 6)

NUMBER	WHAT IT IS
Scaia: founded 2026; ~6 → 25+ people in 2 years; Barkawi Group since 1994, ~1,200 people	The firm

13. Traps

Don't guess the client. "Magnificent 7 in the Bay Area" is all you know. Say "the lighthouse client."

Don't overclaim tools. Kinaxis, o9 and LlamaSoft: not hands-on. Say it once, plainly, then show the planning logic you've built. Over-claiming is the fastest way to lose a former consulting partner.

Don't sound like you're leaving the hands-on work. Scaia sells execution. "I want to be more strategic" is the wrong answer here.

Drop the Amazon vocabulary. No "Leadership Principles," no "WBR" without saying "weekly business review," no "p99" without "99 out of 100."

Don't say "we" for your decisions. "I set the gate. I wrote the definitions. I held the wave."

Don't run long. 45 minutes. Ninety seconds per story, then stop.

Illustrative numbers are illustrative. Cost-per-ticket, the ATS lines, the postponement and the $100M case are examples. Your real results are the bolded outcomes. Say "for example" when you use the others.